evidence suggests that they had an immediate and dramatic impact on the South.

The worship of the Mother Goddess, along with the linga fertility cult, snake-worship, tree-worship, hero-worship and other forms of folk-worship, had long been practised in Tamil country, but it was the Jains who introduced the first clearly defined creed, with the Buddhists hot on their heels. Both heterodoxies were flexible enough to accommodate elements of existing religious practices by turning local deities into protectors and supporting demi-gods. So the widely worshipped Naga snake deities became protectors of both Jainism and Buddhism, which is why we find Jain images in stone and bronze of the Naga snake-king Dharana sheltering the twenty-third *Tirthankara*, Parshvanatha, with his hood from a storm sent by a demon, Buddhist images of the Naga snake-king Muchalinda sheltering the Buddha-to-be for seven days and nights while he meditates, and, in due course, Hindu images of the thousand-headed cosmic Naga snake-king Ananta offering his coils as a couch for Lord Vishnu.

The Jains and Buddhists also gave roles as guardian attendants to the male and female nature-spirits known as *yaksha*s and *yakshi*s, the Jains giving particular prominence to a nature-spirit named Ambika Devi, or ‘goddess-mother’, who became the protector of the twenty-second *Tirthankara*, Neminatha. The two heterodoxies also developed a great partiality for the overtly sexual tree-and-water *yakshi* Vrikshaka, better known as a *salabhanjika*, or ‘branch-breaker’, who by symbolically breaking a branch of a sal tree – perhaps a rudimentary form of pruning – brought increased fertility. Exquisite carvings of these *salabhanjika*s, naked but for a jewelled girdle and with one arm grasping a tree’s branch and one leg wrapped round its trunk, decorated the earliest Buddhist and Jain stupa railings at Bharhut and the Great Stupa at Sanchi. In time, Hinduism followed suit, with some of the finest images ever carved in